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Tulja Bhavani Temple

Shree Tulaja Bhavani Temple (Marathi: **श्री तुळजाभवानी मंदिर**), a 12th century CE Hindu temple dedicated to goddess Bhavani built in 12th century CE by Mahamandaleshwara Māradadeva of the Kadamb dynasty, considered as one of the 51 Shakti Pithas, is located on the banks of Mandakini River and Bori Dam in Yamunachala Hill of Balaghat Range of Tuljapur, 45 km northeast of Solapur, in Dharashiv district of Maharashtra in India.[1]

This Tuljapur Bhavani temple, along with Renuka temple at Mahur 330 km northeast of Tuljapur, Mahalaxmi temple at Kolhapur 275 southwest of Tuljapur, and Saptashringi temple at Vani 375 northwest of Tuljapur, forms the four great Shaktipitha in Maharashtra.[2]

There are other temples of Tulja Bhavani in India, Chittorgarh Fort Tulja Bhavani Temple at Chittorgarh built in 1537–1540 960 km north of Tuljapur, and the Patnakuva Tulja Bhavani Temple at Patnakuva village of Gandhinagar district in Gujarat 1,000 km northwest of Tuljapur.

Shree Tulja Bhavani Temple

तुळजा भवानी मन्दिर

Main entrance gate (Raje Shahaji Mahadwar)

Religion	
Affiliation	Hinduism
District	Dharashiv district
Deity	Bhavani (as Amba Bhavani or Amba Bai)
Festivals	Navaratri Dussehra Ganesh Chaturthi Holi Deepawali (Diwali)
Governing body	Shri Tulja Bhavani Temple Trust
Features	Temple tree: 3 big trees
Location	
Location	Raje Shahaji Mahadwar Road, Jijamata Nagar, Tuljapur,

Goddess Bhavani at Tuljapur

Etymology and other names of Bhavani

"Bhavani" literally translates to "giver of life", meaning the power of nature or the source of creative energy. She is considered to be a mother goddess who provides to her devotees and also plays the role of dispensing justice by killing Asuras (demons).

The Goddess "Tulja Bhavani" is also known as Tulaja, Turaja, Tvarita and Amba.

Goddess Bhavani the incarnation of Goddess Durga

Bhavani is a form of the goddess Durga who is worshipped in Maharashtra, Gujarat, Rajasthan, Rajasthan, entire North India, Northern Karnataka, and Nepal, Andhra Pradesh.[3]

Skanda Purana legend of Goddess Bhavani

One of the earliest legend related to the Goddess Bhavani is mentioned in the Skanda Purana (8th century or earlier) as it finds a mention in that holy script. The legend involves a demon, Madhu-Kaitabh, who was wreaking havoc upon both the gods and humans. Unable to find any solution, they turned to Lord Brahma for help, who advised them to turn to the Goddess Shakti. She took up the form of a destroyer, and powered by the other Sapta Matas, namely Brahmani who manifested from Brahma, Chamunda from Chandi, Kaumari from Kartikeya, Indrani from Indra, Maheshvari from Shiva, Vaishnavi from Vishnu, and Varahi from Varaha, vanquished the demon and restored peace. Legend also states that Bhavani finished another demon that had taken up the disguise of a buffalo (Mahisha), and took shelter on the Yamunachala Hill which is part of Balaghat mountain range.[4]

According to this legend, there was a sage named Kardama with a consort named "Anubhuthi" with their infant child, in this area. After sage Kardama's death, his wife "Anubhuthi" performed a penance for goddess in the name of Bhavani on the Yamunachala hillock on the banks of the river Mandakini River (presently known as the Bori River) to look after her child. While performing the penance two Rakshasa (demon) jointly known as Madhu-Kaitabha (also called "Kukur") tried to disturb her penance during which the Goddess Bhavani came to the aid of "Anubuti" and killed the demon "Kukur". From that day onwards, the Goddess Bhavani came to be known a Tulaja Bhavani. The goddess on the prayer of her favourite devotee settled in Tuljapur on the Yamunachala Hill of Balaghat

	Dharashiv district, Maharashtra - 413601
State	Maharashtra
Country	India

Location in Maharashtra

Tulja Bhavani Temple (Maharashtra)

Coordinates	18.011386°N 76.125641°E
Architecture	
Type	Hemadpanti architecture
Style	Hemadpanthi style
Creator	Maratha King Mahamandaleshwara Māradadeva
Established	1169
Completed	1169
Specifications	
Inscriptions	Dharur Inscription
Materials	Black stone
Elevation	648 m (2,126 ft)
Website	
shrituljabhavanitempletrust.org (https://shrituljabhavanitempletrust.org/)	

Range, where the temple was built in 12th century. Since then the Mother Goddess came to be called as Bhavani of Tuljapur or Tulja Bhavani.

Goddess Bhavani as Kuldevi

The Goddess is kuldevi (clan goddess) for many Maratha clans of Maharashtra.[5] The Goddess is either revered by or is the Family Deity for many other Marathi castes at different levels of social hierarchy[6] The Goddess is either revered by or is the Family Deity for many castes including Kadam, Bhope, Banjara or Lamani or Gorbanjara, Dhangar, Mali, Deshastha Brahmin, Bharbhunja, Burud, Kolhati, Gavli, Jogi, Johar, San Teli, Gavandi, Pangul, Sonar, Lonari, Kasar, Bhute, Kalar, Aagri and Koli, Bhavsar, etc.

Temple complex

12th century Bhavani Bhavani main temple

Idol of Tulja Bhawani in the sanctum.

Temple history

Tulja Bhavani Temple here was built in the 12th century CE. The Goddess is said to be swayambhu` ("self-manifested" or "that which is created by its own accord").[a] There is a "yagna kund" (holy fire pit) in front of this temple.

Idol of Goddess Bhavani in the temple

The idol of Goddess Tulja Bhawani, three-foot tall and made of granite, is with eight arms holding weapons, and bearing the head of the slain demon Mahishasura. Devotees bow in devotion upon seeing the finely shaped, tandla (idol) of the self-manifested goddess, which is adorned with vermilion, ornaments, and decorations.

3 Entrances

Sardar Nimbalkar entrance and related temples

The main entrance of the temple bears the name of Sardar Nimbalkar. As one enters the Sardar Nimbalkar entrance.

- **Markandeya Rishi Temple**: Inside the entrance, there is a temple dedicated to the sage Markandeya Rishi on the right.
- **Tulja Bhavani Temple**: After descending the stairs from the Sardar Nimbalkar entrance, one sees the main Tulja Temple.
- **Gomukh Theerth** and **Kallol Theerth** (**Kalakh**): After alighting from the stairs, there is "Gomukh Theerth" on the right side and "Kalakh", also known as "Kallol Theerth" on the left

side. Before entering the sanctum sanctorum of the Goddess, devotees take a dip here in these theerths (shallow tanks of holy water).

- **Adi Maya Adi Shakti temple**: This temple Adi Maya (Mahadevi) is located on the right side of the main entrance and to the north of the main Tulja Bhavani temple. The pooja ([prayer) is performed here first, before the pooja of Tulja Bhavani. The priests of this temple belong to the Mahar community.
- **Siddhi Vinayak temple**: Situated on the left side of the main entrance of the complex.

Shahaji entrance and Jijabai entrance

The other two entrances are named after the parents of Chhatrapati Shivaji, the founder of the Maratha Empire, his father Shahaji and his mother Jijabai. There are two libraries named, Shree Santh Dnyaneshwar Dharmik Library and Shree Tukaram Dharmik Library respectively.

Chhatrapati Maharaja Shivaji was reputed to frequently visit this temple to seek blessings.

Other temples in the complex

- **Aadishakti Aadimata Matangi Devi temple**: Temple of Goddess Matangi, a tantric manifestation of the goddess Saraswati, is another distinct shrine within the Tulja Bhavani temple complex. The priests of this temple belong to the Mahar community.
- **Annapurna temple**: A temple of goddess Annapurna is also present in the main complex.
- **Datta temple**: Also on the premises.
- **Yamai Devi temple, elder sister of Goddess Tulja Bhavani :** Since there is also a temple of Yamai Devi within the Tuljapur temple complex itself, devotees are able to have the darshan (sacred viewing) of both divine sisters in one place, which is considered a religious convenience. Another temple of Yamai Devi is in Aundh in Satara district 215 km west of Tuljapur. Since the Aundh Yamai Devi temple is considered the original seat (Mulpeeth) of the Yamai Devi, many devotees after visiting the Tulja Bhavani temple at Tuljapur, continue the tradition of visiting Yamai Devi at Aundh or one of the twelve prominent sub-shrines of the goddess Yamai located at Mardi (Solapur district) 35 km northeast of Tuljapur.

Temple management

The day-to-day affairs of the temple are looked after by the trust which is headed by the District Collector. The board of trustees include the deputy collector, the member representing Tuljapur in Maharashtra Legislative Assembly (MLA), the town Mayor (Nagaradhyaksha), and the Tahsildar (subdistrict revenue officer).[7]

Pilgrim numbers

As of 2025, 150,000,000 pilgrims visit the temple every year.[8]

Rituals

Daily rituals

The temple follow a set of elaborate rituals for the deity. These include priests offering a daily ritual bath, change of clothes, and offering food to the deity four times a day. The daily routine also includes offering devotional prayers to the Goddess. In the evening the deity is ceremoniously put to rest.[9]

Special occasions rituals

On special occasions such as the birthday, marriage, in addition to ritual bath, the idol of the Goddess is taken around Tuljapur town in a procession.[9]

Navratri Animal sacrifice ritual

On the ninth day of the autumn Navratri festival and Dussera, goats are sacrificed in honour of the goddess.[10] The actual sacrificial slaughter is carried out by the Mahar community for both the Bhavani temple as well as the Matangi temple.[11]

Maratha priests

Pilgrims usually have longstanding hereditary relationship with a particular "pujari (priest) family"" who serve as the host for the pilgrims by providing accommodation, food, ritual offering to the deity such as sari blouse pieces, bangles, coconut, vermillion, turmeric, puffed rice, flower garlands, and prasada (ritual offering of food to the deity before being distributed to the devotees).The prasada can be vegetarian or at times of meat from a sacrificed goat.[9]

Unlike brahmin or gurav priests at other temples in Maharashtra, the main priests of the Bhavani temple are from the Maratha 153 Palikar & Bhope clan, who offer services to the pilgrims.[11]

The priests of two other temples, Matangi Devi Temple and Adimaya Devi Temple in the Tulha Bhavani temple complex, belong to the Mahar community.[11]

Development plans

Tulja Bhavani Temple Corridor: In 2025, INR 1,865 crore plan was announced by the Government of Maharashtra for the overall development of the Tulja Bhavani Temple Corridor, which will be completed over three and half years, i.e. December 2028.[8]

See also

India portal

Hinduism portal

- Dharashiv Caves, 5th century temple caves 8 km west of Dharashiv and 30 km north of Tulja Bhavani Temple

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Notes

a. It is true that God or Goddess is always referred as ‘swayambhu’ in Vedas, Puranas and many legends. But it does not refer to the stone idol installed in a temple. What is attributed is to the invisible Supreme power.

External links

- Official website (https://shrituljabhavani.org/)

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